Okoboji

By Suzanne Bradbeer

__Alan Harper__ – mid 40s / 60s – an artist from Boston; __Annie Hansgen__ – early 20s
" / " indicates an overlapping of lines

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(Alan and Annie, looking at West Okoboji Lake. It is early morning in Iowa)

ALAN: **(Pg 170-176)** So this is it. The famous blue lake . . .

ANNIE: Yeah.

ALAN: Cobalt. Cobalt blue. It's almost a Prussian blue, but not quite. No, it's definitely cobalt. My favorite color.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Welcome to Okoboji Lake*
ACTOR: *-- where ordinary conversations ripple with unspoken revelation –*
ACTRESS: *-- where every glance, every pause, suggests a deeper story..*
ACTOR: *Here on the shore, Alan (a father) and Annie (his son's friend) are drawn together by necessity –*
ACTRESS: *-- or coincidence, to exchange words that reverberate in the stillness.*
ACTOR: *Often the battles that matter most:*
ACTRESS: *Depression, despair . . . guilt*
TOGETHER: *Are the ones we cannot see.*
ACTRESS: *But somewhere, perhaps, there might exist a glimmer of grace.*
TOGETHER: *Okoboji by Suzanne Bradbeer*

ALAN: Have you ever been to Boston?

ANNIE: No. I'd like to someday.

ALAN: There's a painting at the Museum of Fine Arts, it's by William Merritt Chase, have you heard of William Merritt Chase?

ANNIE: No.

ALAN: I don't much care for him, I find him a little prissy in his subject matter, but I like this particular painting, and he uses this exact shade of blue.

ANNIE: I'd love to see it.

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ALAN: This exact shade of blue . . .. *(uncomfortable, he looks behind them)* Look at all those ***trees.***

ANNIE: I know, aren't they beautiful? Oak trees are my favorite.

ALAN: I hate nature.

ANNIE: *(picking up a feather from the ground)* Look, a hawk's feather! Look!

ALAN: Are you Indian? I mean, sorry, Native American?

ANNIE: No.

ALAN: How do you know so much about the fauna and the flora?

ANNIE: You mean, the hawk's feather?

ALAN: Hawk's feather, oak trees, yes, how do you know all that?

ANNIE: Um, the oak is a pretty common tree? And the red-tailed hawk, they've made their homes all over this country -- in meadows, mountains -- the desert. They even have them in cities, like where you're from, Boston; I even heard there were these red-tailed hawks on Fifth Avenue in New York, a hawk couple named Pale Male and Lola.

ALAN: Fascinating. *(looks back at the lake, considering)* They say this is one of only three true blue water lakes on the planet. 'Course you probably already know that, what with your obsessive cataloguing of the natural world. *(no response from Annie)* One of three on the planet and yet I had never heard of West Okoboji Lake until a year ago. Do you know where the other two blue water lakes are?

ANNIE: Lake Geneva in Switzerland, and Lake Louise in Alberta, Canada.

ALAN: Correct. I wonder how many people in the world have seen all three? Maybe there's a group, a society you can join, I could probably go online and find the Blue Water Lake Club.

ANNIE: Sounds neat.

ALAN: Sounds hideous. I hate clubs. Turns out though, I could be a founding member.

ANNIE: You've seen all three? Really?

ALAN: Lake Geneva, beautiful of course. Lake Louise, Brian was conceived in the Hotel Banff on the shores of Lake Louise. At least that's what we always liked to say. Brian's mother and I were very . . . at any rate, let's just say it's hard to pinpoint the exact moment. But I like to

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think it was in the Hotel Banff. *(beat)* I'm always quite moved by rarity. One of only three blue water lakes. Biggest diamond in the world. Only son.

ANNIE: *(beat)* Brian's eyes were this color.

ALAN: Yes.

ANNIE: That was one of the first things I noticed about him. I've never met anyone else with eyes that were/ so blue.

ALAN: Brian's great-great-great grandfather was a Colonel in the Revolutionary Army. A Colonel is a very high rank, during the Revolution it was second only to General and, and I, I don't know what made me think of that except that he, the Colonel, he seemed to be quite fond of nature too. We have a few of his letters; he survived the war and wrote constantly, ***incessantly*** about his travels up and down the Massachusetts Shore. They're quite valuable these letters – Boring but valuable. Why are you smiling?

ANNIE: We used to call Brian 'the Colonel'. Even in the short time we knew him. It was very important to him that people respect the lake and the woods. He always spoke to everyone in a nice way, but he was very firm about it, if they were littering, or being careless, he was very firm.

ALAN: Were they mean to him?

ANNIE: Who?

ALAN: Anyone, was ***anyone*** mean to him?

ANNIE: No. ***No.***

ALAN: He was bullied quite a lot when he was in school.

ANNIE: He told me.

ALAN: So, calling him the Colonel, they weren't being, mocking/ or, or ?

ANNIE: No, not at all --

ALAN: Because a boy less like a Colonel you could hardly hope to find.

ANNIE: We called him the Colonel because he / had very ---

ALAN: Yes, I remember that he advised people not to litter.

ANNIE: It wasn't just that . . . he, he had standards of behavior, very high standards of behavior

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-- for himself especially. And he was very, responsible and, and -- Oh! He always identified time in that military way, like nine o'clock at night wasn't nine o'clock, it was 2100 hours.

ALAN: 2100 hours, yes. He started doing that when he was about seven, for some reason.

ANNIE: And he valued loyalty. And doing the right thing. And niceness . . . I think he valued niceness most of all.

ALAN: Brian was much more like his mother. I had a good night's sleep that night.

ANNIE: Sir?

ALAN: I don't usually sleep well, but that night I was sleeping very well. Until the call. I don't understand how I slept through . . . that moment. I don't understand that. They say he died immediately.

ANNIE: Yes.

ALAN: I thought maybe they lied. To spare me, I thought maybe they lied.

ANNIE: No.

ALAN: *(This is what he's been waiting to say)* See, I would prefer to think that you fired the gun accidentally, accidentally of course -- but I would prefer to think that you fired it, rather than . . . rather than what you want me to think.

ANNIE: I don't want you to think anything.

ALAN: But can you understand that? Can you understand how a father would prefer to think that?

ANNIE: . . . I guess.

ALAN: So this, this ***inquiry,*** or inquest, or

ANNIE: Autopsy, it was just / an autopsy-

ALAN: Whatever it was, it doesn't have a workable result for me.

ANNIE: But why -- I mean, that was a month ago – why / are you

ALAN: And I've been giving it a great deal of thought in the last month, a great deal. As you can imagine. And I just think that maybe you should admit what ***really*** happened.

ANNIE: I'm sorry, but didn't you read the report? The forensics were very clear.

ALAN: I don't care about God-damn forensics! I care about my boy. You were there; you could

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have shot him, you'd / both been

ANNIE: No.

ALAN: Yes! A bunch of you had been drinking earlier that night, you admitted as much. And maybe, maybe you'd never held a gun before / and maybe you-

ANNIE: How can you say that to me?

ALAN: Where did he get the gun?

ANNIE: It's not hard to get a gun.

ALAN: Maybe you were curious and wanted to see what it felt like and maybe Brian was trying to show you but neither of you realized that the gun was loaded / and maybe

ANNIE: Is this why you came all the way back here?

ALAN: No one would blame you. I would make sure / of that.

ANNIE: He shot himself in front of me, Mr. Harper.

ALAN: No he didn't. It was an accident.

ANNIE: He shot himself in front of me.

ALAN: If you ever have children you might understand how cruel you're being right now.

ANNIE: *(beat)* I'm sorry.

ALAN: My son was not cruel.

ANNIE: No, he wasn't.

ALAN: That's a very cruel thing, if it's true. To do what he did in front of you.

ANNIE: I don't think he meant to.

ALAN: See! It was an accident!

ANNIE: I just meant that he didn't mean for me to see; he didn't expect / me to --

ALAN: Why can't you say it was an accident-just tell me it was a God damn accident -- what the hell is wrong with you?!

ANNIE: . . . It was an accident.

ALAN: . . . I could wish you were a better liar.

ANNIE: . . . Me too. *(beat)* I knew he was depressed. I think he was depressed for a long time. We talked about it sometimes. He said he considered it part of his life. But it wasn't the only

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part. And it doesn't take away from the things that made him happy. This lake made him happy, especially this time of day, especially right here. Remembering his Mom made him happy. And you, your paintings, your paintings made him happy.

ALAN: I'm not painting anymore.

ANNIE: You don't hate nature.

ALAN: What?!

ANNIE: You said you hated nature. You're a painter, I don't think you hate nature.

ALAN: You don't know me. You don't know me and you barely knew my son -- you knew him, what, ten months? You can't know someone in ten months.

ANNIE: He talked about showing you this lake. He said the first thing you'd do would be to identify the exact color.

ALAN: Anyone would do that.

ANNIE: And say it was your favorite color and then mention some obscure painter who has three names.

ALAN: William Merritt Chase is hardly obscure. *(beat)* It's true; Brian was often amused by what he called my, predictability. Did he tell you that? *(Annie nods)* What else did he say about me?

ANNIE: I know that he loved you, Mr. Harper.

ALAN: *(beat)* I'm not a warm person. I am aware of that, you know. *(Annie rolls her eyes)* Did you just roll your eyes?

ANNIE: Did I? Sorry. I thought I just rolled them in my mind. Sorry.

ALAN: It's all right. *(looking around)* This is a nice spot. And it was nice of you to bring me here. You seem like a nice kid. I'm ready to go back now. *(walks off, then looks back at Annie who hasn't moved)* Are you coming?

ANNIE: . . . I'm not a nice kid.

ALAN: What?

ANNIE: *(distraught)* I let him down. I'm not a nice kid! He needed me and I let him down.

ALAN: How?

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ANNIE: He reached out to me -- that last week. He left me a couple messages, but I was preoccupied. I don't even know with what, with ***nothing***, with my own boring problems, which were nothing, they were nothing! I didn't get back to him until the party. I knew he was depressed and I didn't get back to him until that party. What is wrong with me?!

ALAN: *(carefully)* I shouldn't have said those things to you. I'm sorry.

ANNIE: I'm not a nice kid!

ALAN: You didn't let him down.

ANNIE: You don't know!

ALAN: I do know. I know a few things. I've lived a long time and in spite of all evidence to the contrary, I know a few things. You didn't let him down. *(looking at her)* You don't believe me? *(Annie shakes her head)* I'm your elder. I think that means you have to believe whatever I say.

ANNIE: I'm sorry, but I don't.

ALAN: Well. Then we'll just have to stay in touch till I figure out how to convince you. Can we do that? *(Annie shrugs, helpless) (gently)* Let's do that, let's stay in touch. Now tell me something. Why are you still carrying around that dirty feather?

ANNIE: *(looking at the feather, surprised she still has it)* Birds are believed to carry messages of the spirit. Did you know that? A bird feather represents strength and . . . protection. And a hawk feather, a hawk feather is extra special. If you find a feather like this, you're supposed to let it go back into the wind with a prayer, or . . . or a message.

ALAN: I thought you weren't an Indian.

ANNIE: I'm not, I'm just from Iowa.

ALAN: *(of the feather)* You're supposed to send it back into the wind?

ANNIE: *(nods)* With a prayer or a message.

ALAN: Then, let's do it.

ANNIE: Do what?

ALAN: Let's send a message. *(Annie hesitates. Then she holds the feather aloft. Alan stands next to her, but not touching her. Beat. Annie lets go of the feather and they watch it fly off over*

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the lake)

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Suzanne Bradbeer
Book: The Best Ten-Minute Plays 2012, Pgs 170-176
ISBN: 978-1575257938
Publisher: Smith and Kraus
Date (Month/Year): June 2013

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

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